

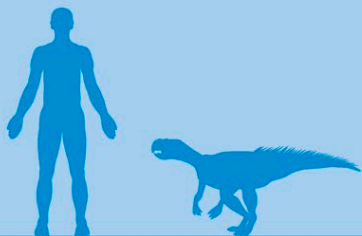
ILL-FATED BUNCH

PSITTACOSAURUS YOUNG

Paleontologists were initially puzzled when they discovered this group of 30 young *Psittacosaurus* fossilized together alongside the skull of a larger individual. Many experts wondered how these dinosaurs came to be in one place, with some suggesting that it was evidence of a parent taking care of its young. However, further examination revealed that although the larger individual was older than the others, it was not yet an adult. Paleontologists now think that this set of fossils shows cooperation among *Psittacosaurus* young of various ages, probably as a way of defending themselves against predators.

AT A GLANCE

- **YEAR OF DISCOVERY** 2012
- **PLACE** Liaoning, China
- **STUDIED BY** Brandon Hedrick and team
- **LIVED** 125–120 MYA



The skull size suggests that the larger individual was probably around 4 or 5 years old.

VOLCANIC MUDFLOW

After a volcanic eruption, ash-laden debris often gets mixed with water to form devastating mudflows, which can cover vast areas in concretelike mud. The group of *Psittacosaurus* young shown in the main image may have been the victims of such a mudflow. They were found preserved in volcanic rock, and the orientation of their bodies suggested that they had been engulfed together.

